

أَعُوذُ بِاللَّهِ مِنَ الشَّيْطَانِ الرَّجِيمِ
بِسْمِ اللَّهِ الرَّحْمَنِ الرَّحِيمِ

Lisan ul Quran — Lecture 26

The Murakkab Idafi • exceptions and the Asma' Sittah

1. A recap of the Murakkab Idafi and the Dama'ir

A construction of at least two nouns in which one noun is related to another is called a *Murakkab Idafi*. The noun that is related is the *Mudaf* and the one to which it is related is the *Mudaf Ilayh*.

In a *Murakkab Idafi* the *dama'ir* are used in the place of the *Mudaf Ilayh*. Since the *Mudaf Ilayh* is always *Majroor*, the *Majroor dama'ir* alone come here, and being written joined to the word they are called *Muttasil dama'ir*.

The four rules for the Dameer -hu

What precedes the Dameer	Form	Examples
a fathah or a dammah	أُ	كِتَابُهُ ، مَدِينَتُهُ
a kasrah	اِ	رُسُلِهِ ، كُتُبِهِ
a silent yaa'	اَ	فِيهِ ، أَخِيهِ
all other cases	هُ	كِتَابَاهُ ، مِنْهُ ، أَخُوهُ

2. The rules applied in Surah 'Abasa

فَإِذَا جَاءَتِ الصَّاحَّةُ ﴿١﴾ يَوْمَ يَقْرَأُ الْمَرْءُ مِنْ أَخِيهِ ﴿٢﴾ وَأُمِّهِ وَأَبِيهِ ﴿٣﴾ وَصَاحِبَتِهِ وَبَنِيهِ ﴿٤﴾ لِكُلِّ امْرِئٍ مِنْهُمْ يَوْمَئِذٍ شَأْنٌ يُغْنِيهِ ﴿٥﴾

(Surah 'Abasa: 33 to 37)

Translation: Then when the deafening blast comes, on the day a man will flee from his brother, and his mother and his father, and his wife and his sons. For every man among them that day will be a matter to occupy him entirely.

- When a silent yaa' comes before the *dameer* اَ, a plain kasrah is placed beneath it, as may be seen in بَنِيهِ and أَبِيهِ, أَخِيهِ.

- Against this, if the letter before the *dameer* carries only a kasrah, the *dameer* is written and read with a standing kasrah, as in **أُمِّهِ** and **صَاحِبَتِهِ**, where a kasrah stands beneath the meem and the taa' respectively.

3. Exceptional cases in the Qur'an

Alongside these rules there are places in the Qur'an that stand outside the general grammatical principles. Reflecting on them brings out a fine point about the style of the Qur'an.

3.1 Bihi — a plain kasrah where a standing one was expected

وَمَا أُنْزِلَ اللَّهُ مِنْ السَّمَاءِ مِنْ مَّاءٍ فَآحْيَا بِهِ الْأَرْضَ بَعْدَ مَوْتِهَا

(Surah al-Baqarah: 164)

Translation: And in the water that Allah sent down from the sky, by which He gave life to the earth after its death.

In this verse **بِهِ** shows a plain kasrah on the pronoun, although a kasrah precedes it. By the rule a standing kasrah should have come here.

3.2 Lahu — a plain dammah where an inverted one was expected

يُضَعَفُ لَهُ الْعَذَابُ يَوْمَ الْقِيَمَةِ وَيَخْلُدُ فِيهِ مُهَانًا

(Surah al-Furqan: 69)

Translation: The punishment will be doubled for him on the Day of Resurrection, and he will abide therein in disgrace.

In this verse a fathah precedes the pronoun in **لَهُ**, so an inverted dammah should have come; but a plain dammah appears instead.

The reason for both — an important rule of Tajweed

The rule: Whenever a word carrying a standing fathah, a standing kasrah or an inverted dammah is read **joined to the word that follows** — that is, in *wasl* — it leaves its long form and turns into a plain vowel.

In Surah al-Baqarah verse 164 the word **بِهِ**, and in Surah al-Furqan verse 69 the word **لَهُ**, were joined to the lam of the words that follow, so their standing and inverted vowels turned into a plain kasrah and a plain dammah respectively. This change is made to keep the recitation flowing.

3.3 Feehi — a standing kasrah where a plain one was expected

In that same verse of Surah al-Furqan, the word **فِيهِ** should have carried a plain kasrah, since a silent yaa' precedes it. Yet a standing kasrah is written there.

3.4 'Alayhu — a dammah where a kasrah was expected

وَمَنْ أَوْفَىٰ بِمَا عَاهَدَ عَلَيْهُ اللَّهُ فَسَيُؤْتِيهِ أَجْرًا عَظِيمًا

(Surah al-Fath: 10)

Translation: And whoever fulfils the covenant he has made with Allah, He will soon give him a great reward.

In this verse of Surah al-Fath, in **عَلَيْهِ اللَّهُ**, the pronoun after the silent yaa' is read with its original vowel, a dammah, rather than with a kasrah.

The most important conclusion: These exceptional cases are proof that **the rules of Arabic grammar were framed with the Qur'an before them**, and not that the Qur'an is bound by those rules. Such fine points make plain the inimitability of the Qur'an and its distinctive style.

4. Recognising the Muttasil Majroor Dama'ir

In Arabic grammar the *dama'ir* that come joined to another word are called *Muttasil dama'ir*. The *Muttasil dama'ir* are of two kinds: *Majroor* and *Mansoob*.

Something interesting: The outward forms of the *Mansoob* and *Majroor Muttasil dama'ir* are a hundred percent identical. They are told apart by the place in which they are used, not by their shape.

An easy test: If a *dameer* is joined to a **noun**, it is necessarily *Majroor*, and the two together form a *Murakkab Idafi*.

The *Majroor Muttasil dama'ir* are used in two places in Arabic:

- in the place of the *Mudaf Ilayh* — as in **كِتَابُهُ**
- in a *Murakkab Jarri*, that is, after a *Harf ul Jarr* — as in **بِهِ** and **عَلَيْهِ**

5. The style of translating a Murakkab Idafi

The *Murakkab Idafi* is the most frequently used *Murakkab Naqis* in the Qur'an and hadith. Generally its translation places "of" between the two words, or renders it with a possessive — "Zayd's house", "my pen", "your house".

But an exception: In many places in the Qur'an there are constructions that are a *Murakkab Idafi* by their l'raab, yet whose translation is not made with the customary "of". Four words in particular deserve mention: كُلٌّ ، بَعْضٌ ، أَصْحَابٌ ، أَكْثَرُ.

5.1 The word Kull

In Arabic the word كُلٌّ is always used as a *Mudaf*, and carries neither *alif lam* nor *Tanween*. The noun or pronoun that follows it is *Majroor*.

The rule of translation: When a *Nakirah* noun comes after كُلٌّ, it is rendered not as "the whole of a thing" but as "every".

Construction	Literal rendering	Idiomatic rendering
كُلُّ شَيْءٍ	the whole of a thing	every thing
كُلُّ مُسْلِمٍ	the whole of a Muslim	every Muslim

إِنَّ اللَّهَ عَلَى كُلِّ شَيْءٍ قَدِيرٌ

(Surah al-Baqarah: 20)

Translation: Indeed Allah is over every thing competent.

Two specimens in one hadith

طَلَبُ الْعِلْمِ فَرِيضَةٌ عَلَى كُلِّ مُسْلِمٍ

Translation: Seeking knowledge is an obligation upon every Muslim.

This short hadith holds two fine specimens of the *Murakkab Idafi* together.

- طَلَبُ الْعِلْمِ — here the translation uses "of": the seeking of knowledge.
- كُلُّ مُسْلِمٍ — here كُلٌّ, though a *Mudaf*, joins with the *Nakirah* noun after it to give the sense of "every".

5.2 The word Ashab

The plural of صَاحِب is أَصْحَاب, which is used abundantly in the Qur'an as a *Mudaf*. By the rules, the noun after it is *Majroor* and it forms a complete *Murakkab Idafi*; but its translation is generally given in the sense of "the people of".

أَلَمْ تَرَ كَيْفَ فَعَلَ رَبُّكَ بِأَصْحَابِ الْفِيلِ

(Surah al-Fil: 1)

Translation: Have you not seen how your Lord dealt with the people of the elephant?

Here أَصْحَاب is the *Mudaf* and الْفِيلِ the *Mudaf Ilayh*; yet rather than "the companions of the elephant" the rendering "the people of the elephant" carries the sense more properly.

5.3 The word Akthar

The word أَكْثَر is likewise used in the Qur'an as a *Mudaf* without *alif lam* or *Tanween*. When an *Ism Dhahir* or a pronoun follows it in the *Majroor* state, the whole is a *Murakkab Idafi*.

Construction	Literal rendering	Idiomatic rendering
أَكْثَرُ النَّاسِ	the most of the people	most people
أَكْثَرُهُمْ	their most	most of them

بَلْ أَكْثَرُهُمْ لَا يَعْقِلُونَ

(Surah al-'Ankabut: 63)

Translation: Rather, most of them do not use reason.

5.4 The word Ba'd

The word بَعْض is also among those used consistently as a *Mudaf*. When it becomes a *Mudaf*, its translation is made without "of".

أَفَتُؤْمِنُونَ بِبَعْضِ الْكِتَابِ وَتَكْفُرُونَ بِبَعْضٍ

(Surah al-Baqarah: 85)

Translation: Do you then believe in part of the Book and disbelieve in part?

Here بَعْضِ الْكِتَابِ is rendered not as "the part of the Book" in the possessive sense but as "part of the Book".

Likewise when it joins a pronoun, as in بَعْضُكُمْ or بَعْضُهُمْ, the sense is "some of you" and "some of them".

The four words at a glance

Word	Example	Style of translation
كُلٌّ	كُلُّ شَيْءٍ	in the sense of "every"

Word	Example	Style of translation
أَصْحَاب	أَصْحَابِ الْفِيلِ	in the sense of "the people of"
أَكْثَر	أَكْثَرُ النَّاسِ	by bringing "most" first
بَعْض	بَعْضُ الْكُتُبِ	by bringing "part" or "some" first

6. The Asma' Sittah

Definition: In Arabic grammar the *Asma' Sittah* are those particular nouns whose *I'raab*, when they become a *Mudaf*, is expressed through letters — waw, alif and yaa' — and not through the vowels of dammah, fathah and kasrah.

These nouns are: أَب (father), أَخ (brother), حَم (father-in-law), فَم (mouth), ذُو (possessor of) and هُن (Hun).

Five or six?: In the reckoning of the grammarians these nouns are **six**, which is why they are called the *Asma' Sittah*. However, the sixth word هُن is very seldom used and does not occur in the Qur'an, so some books call them the *Asma' Khamsah*, the five nouns. Both descriptions are sound.

Of these, the first four take *Tanween*, that is, they are *Munsarif*.

The original forms of these nouns

The waw, alif and yaa' at the end of these nouns do not appear out of nowhere. Their original forms in fact ended in those very letters, which later fell away.

أَب	أَخ	حَم	فَم	هُن	ذُو
أَبُو	أَخُو	حَمُو	فَوُهُ	هَنُو	ذُو

(above, the present form; below, the original form)

It is on account of this origin that these letters reappear when the noun becomes a *Mudaf*.

The I'raab before becoming a Mudaf

When these nouns are not a *Mudaf*, their *I'raab* comes through vowels, just like that of ordinary nouns.

Noun	Raf'	Nasb	Jarr
أَب (father)	أَب	أَبَا	أَبِ
أَخ (brother)	أَخ	أَخَا	أَخِ
حَم (father-in-law)	حَم	حَمَا	حَمِ
فَم (mouth)	فَم	فَمَا	فَمِ

The I'raab after becoming a Mudaf

When the *Asma' Sittah* come in the position of the *Mudaf* in a *Murakkab Idafi*, their *I'raab* changes. This change makes no difference to the meaning; only the final shape of the word alters — and that is exactly what *I'raab* means.

State	أَب	أَخ	حَم	فَم	هَن	ذُو
Raf'	أَبُو	أَخُو	حَمُو	فُو	هَنُو	ذُو
Nasb	أَبَا	أَخَا	حَمَا	فَا	هَنَا	ذَا
Jarr	أَيِّ	أَخِي	حَمِي	فِي	هَنِي	ذِي

An easy way to remember: A waw in the state of *raf'*, an alif in *nasb*, and a yaa' in *jarr*.

Four conditions

The *l'raab* of these nouns comes through letters only when four conditions are met. These were covered in detail in Lecture 12.

- They must be *mukabbarah*, that is, not diminutives.
- They must be *mufrad*, that is, not dual or plural.
- They must be *Mudaf*.
- They must be annexed to some noun other than the *Yaa' ul Mutakallim*.

7. The Asma' Sittah in practice

7.1 The word Ab

The word **أَب** means father. As a *Mudaf* it comes as **أَبُو** in the state of *raf'*, **أَبَا** in *nasb*, and **أَبِي** in *jarr*.

With an Ism Dhahir	With a Dameer
Hamid's father — أَبُو حَامِدٍ	his father — أَبُوهُ
Zayd's father — أَبُو زَيْدٍ	their father — أَبُوهُمْ
	your father — أَبُوكَ

All these examples are a *Murakkab Idafi*, since **أَبُو** is the *Mudaf* and the noun or pronoun after it the *Mudaf Ilayh*.

7.2 Kunyahs too are a Murakkab Idafi

In Arabic every *kunyah* consists of a *Murakkab Idafi*.

أَبُوبَكْرٍ ، أَبُولَهَبٍ ، أَبُوتَرَابٍ ، أَبُوهَرَيْرَةَ

In all these the first word is the *Mudaf* and the second the *Mudaf Ilayh*, which is why they are all a *Murakkab Idafi*.

7.3 The word Akh

The word **أَخ** means brother. As a *Mudaf* its forms are **أَخُو**, **أَخَا** and **أَخِي**.

- **أَخُو زَيْدٍ** — Zayd's brother
- **أَخُوهُ** — his brother
- **أَخُوكَ** — your brother

7.4 The word Ham

The word **حَم** is used for a relation by marriage. As a *Mudaf* its forms are **حَمُو**, **حَمَا** and **حَمِي**.

- **حَمُو حَامِدٍ** — Hamid's father-in-law
- **حَمُو زَيْنَبَ** — Zaynab's father-in-law
- **حَمُوهُ** — his father-in-law

7.5 The word Fam

The word **فَم** means mouth. As a *Mudaf* its forms are **فُو**, **فَا** and **فِي**.

- **فُو زَيْدٍ** — Zayd's mouth

- فُوكْ — your mouth
- فُوهُمْ — their mouth

Worth noting: What is particular about فَمْ is that when it becomes a *Mudaf* its meem falls away and the waw of the original form فَوْه appears. This is why it becomes فُو and not فَمُو.

7.6 The word Dhu

The word ذُو means "possessor of". It stands apart among the *Asma' Sittah* because it is almost always used as a *Mudaf*. Its forms of *I'raab* are ذُو, ذَا, and ذِي.

Its feminine is ذَات, meaning "possessor of" in the feminine, and it too is used only as a *Mudaf*.

Well-known examples of Dhu

Construction	Translation
ذُو النُّورَيْنِ	possessor of the two lights
ذُو الْفَضْلِ	possessor of bounty
ذُو الرَّحْمَةِ	possessor of mercy
ذُو الْأَوْتَادِ	possessor of the stakes
ذُو الْقَرْنَيْنِ	possessor of the two horns
ذُو الْعَرْشِ	possessor of the Throne

In all these examples ذُو is the *Mudaf* and the word that follows is the *Mudaf Ilayh*.

8. Examples from the Qur'an

قَالُوا يٰذَا الْقَرْنَيْنِ اِنَّ يٰجُوجَ وَمَاجُوجَ مُفْسِدُونَ فِي الْاَرْضِ

(Surah al-Kahf: 94)

Translation: They said: O Dhul-Qarnayn, indeed Ya'juj and Ma'juj are spreading corruption in the land.

Here ذَا الْقَرْنَيْنِ is a *Murakkab Idafi*, and being *Mansoob* after the *Harf un Nida*, it has come as ذَا.

وَيَسْأَلُونَكَ عَنْ ذِي الْقَرْنَيْنِ

(Surah al-Kahf: 83)

Translation: And they ask you about Dhul-Qarnayn.

Here, because of the *Harf ul Jarr* عَنْ, ذُو has changed to ذِي.

وَالسَّمَاءِ ذَاتِ الْحُبُكِ

(Surah adh-Dhariyat: 7)

Translation: By the sky containing pathways.

Here ذَاتِ الْحُبُكِ is a *Murakkab Idafi*. Although ذَات is the feminine form, the noun it qualifies is rendered naturally in English without marking gender.

Summary

1. In a Murakkab Idafi the dama'ir come in the place of the Mudaf Ilayh and are always Majroor Muttasil.
2. If a fathah or dammah precedes the dameer ۛ it becomes ۛ; a kasrah gives ۛ; a silent yaa' gives ۛ; and in all other cases ۛ.
3. In Surah 'Abasa, أَبَاهُ, أَخِيهِ and بَنِيهِ carry a plain kasrah because a silent yaa' precedes.
4. In the same Surah, أُمُّهُ and صَاحِبَتُهُ carry a standing kasrah because a kasrah stands beneath the preceding letter.
5. The rule of Tajweed is that a standing fathah, standing kasrah or inverted dammah turns into a plain vowel when joined to the word that follows.
6. بِه in Surah al-Baqarah 164 and لَهُ in Surah al-Furqan 69 carry plain vowels for exactly this reason.
7. The standing kasrah on فِيهِ in Surah al-Furqan and the dammah on عَلَيْهِ in Surah al-Fath are exceptional cases.
8. These exceptions prove that the rules of Arabic grammar were framed with the Qur'an before them, not that the Qur'an is bound by them.
9. The outward forms of the Mansoob and Majroor Muttasil dama'ir are identical; they are told apart only by their place of use.
10. If a dameer is joined to a noun it is necessarily Majroor, and the two together form a Murakkab Idafi.
11. The Majroor Muttasil dama'ir are used in two places: as the Mudaf Ilayh, and in a Murakkab Jarri.
12. أَصْحَابُ, بَعْضُ, كُلُّ and أَكْثَرُ form a Murakkab Idafi but are not translated with the customary "of".
13. When a Nakirah noun follows كُلُّ it is rendered "every", as in كُلُّ شَيْءٍ, every thing.
14. أَصْحَابُ is rendered in the sense of "the people of", as in أَصْحَابُ الْفِيلِ, the people of the elephant.
15. أَكْثَرُ النَّاسِ is rendered "most people" and أَكْثَرُهُمْ "most of them".
16. بَعْضُ الْكِتَابِ is rendered "part of the Book" rather than in the possessive sense.
17. The Asma' Sittah are the six nouns whose I'raab comes through letters when they are a Mudaf: أَبٌ, أَخٌ, دُوٌّ, حَمٌ, قَمٌ, هَنٌ.
18. Their original forms were هَنَوٌ, قَمَوٌ, حَمَوٌ, أَخَوٌ, أَبَوٌ, and دَوٌ, and it is these very letters that reappear in the Mudaf.
19. As a Mudaf they take a waw in raf', an alif in nasb and a yaa' in jarr.
20. The meem of قَمٌ falls away and the original waw appears, giving قُومٌ and not قَمُومٌ.
21. Every Arabic kunyah is a Murakkab Idafi, as in أَبُو بَكْرٍ and هُرَيْرَةُ.
22. دُوٌّ stands apart among the Asma' Sittah because it is almost always used as a Mudaf, and its feminine is دَوَاتٌ.

Exercise

1. Write all four rules for the dameer ۛ with examples.

2. Take all five words from the verses of Surah 'Abasa and give the reason for the form of the dameer in each.
3. Explain why بِهِ and لَهُ carry plain vowels.
4. Write the rule of Tajweed that applies in the case of wasl.
5. Describe the exceptional cases of فِيهِ and عَلَيْهِ.
6. What conclusion do these exceptions yield about the relation between the Qur'an and grammar?
7. How are the Mansoob and Majroor Muttasil dama'ir told apart?
8. In which two places are the Majroor Muttasil dama'ir used?
9. Name the four words that are not translated with the customary "of".
10. Write the rule for translating كُلِّ and give two Qur'anic examples.
11. Separate both constructions in the hadith طَلَبُ الْعِلْمِ فَرِيضَةٌ عَلَى كُلِّ مُسْلِمٍ and state the difference in their translation.
12. Explain the style of translating أَكْثَرُ أَصْحَابِ and بَعْضُ with examples.
13. Which are the Asma' Sittah? Write their original forms as well.
14. Set out the I'raab of the Asma' Sittah before and after becoming a Mudaf, in the form of a table.
15. Write all four conditions for the I'raab bil Harf of the Asma' Sittah.
16. Why does فَمُ become فَوْ as a Mudaf, and not فَمُو?
17. Why does دُو stand apart among the Asma' Sittah? Write its feminine as well.
18. Write all three states of I'raab of دُو الْقَرْنَيْنِ with Qur'anic examples.

سُبْحَانَكَ اللَّهُمَّ وَبِحَمْدِكَ، أَشْهَدُ أَنْ لَا إِلَهَ إِلَّا أَنْتَ، أَسْتَغْفِرُكَ وَأَتُوبُ إِلَيْكَ

اللَّهُمَّ صَلِّ عَلَى مُحَمَّدٍ وَعَلَى آلِ مُحَمَّدٍ كَمَا صَلَّيْتَ عَلَى إِبْرَاهِيمَ وَعَلَى آلِ إِبْرَاهِيمَ إِنَّكَ حَمِيدٌ مَجِيدٌ

اللَّهُمَّ بَارِكْ عَلَى مُحَمَّدٍ وَعَلَى آلِ مُحَمَّدٍ كَمَا بَارَكْتَ عَلَى إِبْرَاهِيمَ وَعَلَى آلِ إِبْرَاهِيمَ إِنَّكَ حَمِيدٌ مَجِيدٌ